

A Requiem to Naltar

Moin ul Haque

*“There are memories that time does not erase... Forever
does not make loss forgettable, only bearable.”*

Cassandra Clare

I sometimes wonder why things turn out the way they do. At times, I ponder about the cruelty of the fate when bad things happen to good people. And sometimes, I question the abruptness with which moments of joy turn into grief and mourning. Like many others, I seek answers yet hear only the echoes of my musings.

These were the questions in my mind on that fateful day on 8th May 2015, when I was frantically running from one corner of the hill to another, searching for survivors being rescued from the crashed helicopter. I was in a state of shock, disbelief and helplessness, as it became clear that we might have lost some of our colleagues and friends. Slowly, the magnitude and pain of that tragedy began to sink and engulfed us all.

THE JOURNEY

We were all so happy and cheerful when we departed that morning from Nur Khan Air Base aboard a C-130 aircraft especially provided by the Pakistan Air Force. None of us, even in our wildest thoughts, could have foreseen the tragedy that awaited us. The group, comprising 29 Ambassadors and their families, was embarking on a 3-day visit to the beautiful and majestic Northern Areas of Pakistan.

In response to the popular demand of the members of the diplomatic corps, the trip had been organized during my earlier assignment as Chief of Protocol in close coordination with the then Dean of Diplomatic Corps Ambassador of Argentina H.E. Rodolfo Martin Savaria and Serena Hotels CEO Mr. Aziz Boolani. The Pakistan Army, the Pakistan Air Force and the Government of Gilgit-Baltistan played a key role in providing security and logistical support.

Our first stop was Gilgit from where we were ferried in helicopters to Naltar ski resort, where Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif, as a special gesture, was scheduled to host a lunch in honor of the visiting envoys. I along with the Dean, Mr. Boolani, our spouses and few other Ambassadors, was in the second helicopter. As soon as we landed on the small helipad built on the narrow flat strip on a hill, we were whisked away in vehicles to the lunch venue, located a few minutes away amidst the lush mountains. Three other helicopters bringing the remaining guests were to follow.

We alighted from our vehicles and began walking up the green ski slopes, enjoying the magnificent views of the snow-covered peaks and admiring the excellent arrangements made by the Pakistan Air

Force. Along the way up, we met Pakistan's first Winter Olympian Muhammad Abbas, who had represented the country at the Vancouver Winter Olympics during my tenure as Pakistan's first Consul General in Vancouver. As we were taking photographs with him, I suddenly noticed a commotion and somebody mentioning about a helicopter crash.

THE CRASH

I turned and saw black smoke rising in the distance, seemingly from the direction of the helipad. Mr. Boolani and I immediately rushed down in a vehicle, joined by Ambassador Rodolfo. As we approached near the site, I could see smoke and flames behind the trees. My heart was pounding hard and I prayed desperately for the safety of the passengers.

By the time we arrived, rescue operations were already under way. I saw someone being carried on a stretcher. It was my good friend, the amiable Dutch Ambassador Marcel, one of the keenest participants of the trip. I was relieved to see him alive though he was badly injured. With tears in my eyes, I told him that how happy I was to see him safe. I still remember his courageous smile and the witty remark when he said 'Moin, this was not part of the program'.

Soon afterwards, I saw the Ambassadors of Romania and South Africa and the husband of the Ambassador of Lebanon who miraculously escaped the crash unscathed. I was unable to recognize the Ambassador of Indonesia who had severe burns all over his body. He unfortunately succumbed to his injuries later in Singapore, where he had been airlifted for treatment on the special instructions of the Prime Minister.

The Ambassadors of Malaysia and Poland, as well as the latter's wife, had also sustained injuries, though fortunately not life threatening. They were immediately shifted by air and road to CMH Gilgit.

Rodolfo, Aziz and I stood numb with grief and heartbreak when it dawned to us that we had lost the Ambassador of Norway, the Ambassador of Philippines and the wives of the Ambassadors of Malaysia and Indonesia. Three brave Pakistani crew members had also lost their lives.

THE AFTERMATH

Returning from the site of the accident to the anxiously waiting members of the group was perhaps one of the most difficult moments of my life. While I reassured the worried Lebanese Ambassador about the safety of her husband, I choked with emotion found myself unable to disclose the loss of four of our friends.

The events that followed - bringing down the group to Serena Hotel Gilgit, visiting the injured in the hospital, Prime Minister's call to Ambassador Rodolfo to express his shock and grief, visit by Vice Chief of Air Force Air Marshal Saeed Muhammad Khan, prayer meetings for the departed souls, funeral for the deceased arranged by Pakistan Army, flight back to Islamabad, shifting the injured to various hospitals, and the solemn send-off ceremonies for the deceased; all seem surreal even today.

The entire nation of Pakistan was in shock. National mourning was declared. The Prime Minister spoke with the leaders of Indonesia, Norway, Philippines and Poland and deputed Federal Ministers to accompany the mortal remains back to their respective countries. He also addressed a special condolence meeting held at the Foreign Office.

All civilian and military institutions including the Prime Minister's Office, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the Government of Gilgit Baltistan, the Pakistan Army, the Pakistan Air Force, and both civil and military hospitals coped with the aftermath of this grave tragedy with a high degree of professionalism and coordination. Serena Hotels also deserves appreciation for its invaluable support.

ELEVEN YEARS LATER

This month marks eleven years since that tragedy. Even after more than a decade, it remains difficult to fathom why a beautiful journey — organized in a spirit of goodwill and friendship, and to showcase the splendors of the Northern Areas of Pakistan — turned into such a tragedy. It is equally difficult to come to terms with those painful and traumatic moments that remain etched in our memories. While all of us who were there may wish to forget, the memories of those who left us that day will continue to live on.

May the departed souls rest in eternal peace.

The writer is former Chief of Protocol and former Ambassador to France and China.